

USER MANUAL · VERSION 2.0

# Second Brain Starter Kit

Turn your AI assistant into a second brain that remembers what you learn, finds it again before asking you, keeps every project's state on one page, and checks its own health every month. In plain language. No technical background needed.

9 skills

English + Español

Obsidian vault

Free, MIT license

## CAPTURE

### It remembers

End any conversation with "save to my brain". The lasting parts get filed, linked and kept.

## RECALL

### It looks first

Before asking you something, the AI searches your notes. Your brain answers, not your memory.

## CARE

### It stays healthy

Once a month it checks itself and tells you the one thing worth fixing.

## What is new in version 2.0

Five new skills (search, project Doors, checkpoints, closing a session, monthly health), rules that keep the vault from rotting, and an upgrade path for v1 brains that moves nothing. Chapter 1 shows how to upgrade.

[github.com/herreraspaintingba-hub/second-brain-starter-kit](https://github.com/herreraspaintingba-hub/second-brain-starter-kit)

# What is inside

Read it in order the first time. After that, jump to what you need.

| Chapter                           | What you will learn                                                   |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Welcome</b>                    | What a second brain is, and what this kit gives you                   |
| <b>1. Setup and install</b>       | One command, seven questions, ten minutes. And how to upgrade from v1 |
| <b>2. Meet your brain</b>         | The ten drawers of your vault, and how the AI reads it                |
| <b>3. Saving knowledge</b>        | The capture habit, and the rules that keep every note clean           |
| <b>4. Finding things again</b>    | Search before asking: how the brain finds what you already know       |
| <b>5. Working on projects</b>     | Doors, checkpoints, and closing a session without losing anything     |
| <b>6. Deciding what to build</b>  | The idea filter: four scores, one honest verdict                      |
| <b>7. Power moves</b>             | Templates, canvases, bases and clean notes on request                 |
| <b>8. Keeping it healthy</b>      | The monthly checkup, the traffic light, and how to fix what it finds  |
| <b>9. Troubleshooting and FAQ</b> | The fixes for the few things that go wrong                            |
| <b>10. Growing your brain</b>     | Where to take it next, a glossary, and a one-page reference card      |

## How to read this manual

- **Phrases in blue boxes** are things you say to your AI, exactly or in your own words.
- **Green boxes** are tips, **blue boxes** explain what happens behind the scenes, **red boxes** are warnings, and **orange boxes** are golden rules.
- **Grey code lines** are optional. You never have to type them; your AI runs them for you. They are here for the curious.
- Everything works the same in Spanish. A separate Spanish edition of this manual is in the repo.

### The golden rule of this whole kit

You talk, the skills act, the vault remembers. Everything else in this manual is detail.

## WELCOME

# A brain outside your head

What this kit is, in one page.

Every day you learn things: a client's habit, a price that worked, a decision and why you made it, a lesson that cost you money. Most of it is gone in a month. A **second brain** is a place where that knowledge lands, organized, connected, and easy to find again.

This kit turns the AI assistant you already use into the librarian of that place. You talk to it the way you always do. At the end, you say one sentence, and it files what was worth keeping. Next week, when you ask a question, it looks in your notes before asking you.

## The nine skills

| Skill                            | Its one job                                                |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>second-brain-init</code>   | Builds your brain the first time (or upgrades a v1 brain)  |
| <code>save-to-obsidian</code>    | Saves what you learned, with clean links and a session log |
| <code>brain-search</code>        | Searches your notes before answering or asking you         |
| <code>project-door</code>        | Keeps one page per project with where it stands today      |
| <code>session-checkpoint</code>  | A save point during long sessions                          |
| <code>close-session</code>       | Closes a working session so nothing is lost                |
| <code>brain-health</code>        | A monthly checkup with a traffic light and a history       |
| <code>project-advisor</code>     | Scores a new idea before you spend time on it              |
| <code>obsidian-power-user</code> | Works behind the others so every note is clean and linked  |

## The promise

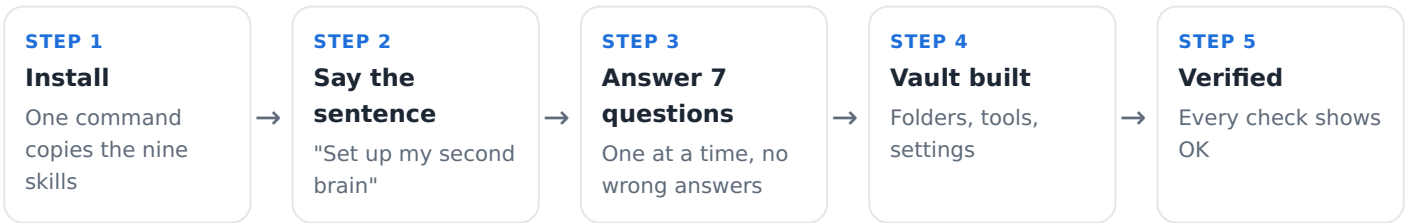
1. **A brain that is set up:** a vault on your computer, organized into clear sections.
2. **A capture habit:** end any conversation with "save to my brain" and trust the good parts are kept.
3. **Recall without asking:** the AI finds what you already decided instead of asking you again.
4. **Projects that pick up where they left off**, even after weeks away.
5. **A brain that stays healthy**, measured the same way every month.

### How long will this take?

Setup is about 10 minutes. Reading this manual, about an hour. Building the habit, a week. After that, it just works.

# 1 Setup and install

The one chapter that feels technical, and even this one is not really. One command, one sentence, seven questions.



## What you need

**Required**

- ✓ An AI assistant that supports skills: Claude (including Cowork), Codex, Gemini, or any assistant that reads `SKILL.md` files.
- ✓ This kit (the installer downloads it for you).

**Optional, and worth it**

- ✓ **Obsidian**, the free app from [obsidian.md](https://obsidian.md): the graph view and clickable links.
- ✓ **Python 3**: unlocks search, the note checker and the health check. Macs and Linux usually have it.

**You do NOT need**

A developer, a paid subscription, a server, Notion, or any coding. If you can paste one line and type a sentence, you can do this.

## Step 1. Install with one command

Open the Terminal (Mac: press Cmd + Space, type "Terminal") and paste:

```
curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/herreraspaintingba-hub/second-brain-starter-kit/main/install.sh | bash
```

It downloads the kit, finds your assistant (Claude, Codex or Gemini) and copies the nine skills into its skills folder. If a skill was already there, the old copy is moved aside, never deleted. At the end it tells you whether Python was found.

| Your assistant      | Where the skills land                                                                        | To choose it yourself    |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Claude Code, Cowork | <code>~/.claude/skills/</code>                                                               | <code>HOST=claude</code> |
| Codex               | <code>~/.codex/skills/</code>                                                                | <code>HOST=codex</code>  |
| Gemini CLI          | <code>~/.gemini/skills/</code>                                                               | <code>HOST=gemini</code> |
| Other               | Copy the nine folders from <code>skills/</code> to wherever your assistant loads skills from |                          |

**The ~ symbol**

It is shorthand for your home folder (for example `/Users/yourname` on a Mac). Your file manager opens there by default.

## Step 2. Say the sentence

Open a new conversation with your assistant and type:

YOU SAY

**"Set up my second brain."**

That wakes up `second-brain-init`, which runs the whole setup. It does not have to be exact: "I just installed the starter kit" works too, and so does "Configura mi segundo cerebro".

### What happens behind the scenes

The assistant sees there is no brain yet (no `CLAUDE.md` settings file), so it runs setup instead of guessing. This happens once. Saying the sentence again later only confirms you are set up.

## Step 3. Answer seven questions

One at a time. There are no wrong answers, and you can change any of them later.

| # | Question                             | Why it asks                                                      |
|---|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | What should I call you?              | So the brain speaks to you by name                               |
| 2 | What do you do? (optional)           | So advice fits your work. Leave blank for personal use           |
| 3 | What do you want to call your brain? | The vault's name, for example "My Second Brain"                  |
| 4 | Where should it live?                | iCloud, Dropbox or OneDrive to sync across devices, or Documents |
| 5 | Which language by default?           | English, Spanish or both. Every skill speaks both anyway         |
| 6 | Do you use Notion?                   | Optional. If yes, the idea filter can copy its verdicts there    |
| 7 | Turn on the monthly health check?    | The brain checks itself on the 1st of each month. Recommended    |

### About question 4

Want your brain on your phone too? Pick iCloud (Mac), OneDrive (Windows) or Dropbox. One computer only? Documents is perfectly fine.

### About question 7

Say yes. It runs once a month, takes seconds, changes none of your notes, and writes one row in a history note. You can turn it off any time.

### No Python?

Setup notices and skips question 7. Every skill still works using plain text search; you can install Python later and the tools start working with no extra setup.

## Step 4. Your vault gets built

The brain creates a set of folders with numbers and clear names, a hidden toolbox, and your settings. It reports each step as it goes.

```
Your Brain/
├─ 00 Inbox/           ← when it does not fit anywhere yet
├─ 01 Personal Knowledge/ ← people, places, routines, lessons
├─ 02 Strategy/        ← vision, goals, decisions, your North Star
├─ 03 Ideas & Notes/    ← ideas, and saved references
├─ 04 Learning/        ← books, courses, tech, business
├─ 05 AI System/       ← how your tools fit together
├─ 06 Session Logs/    ← a record of every session, and checkpoints
├─ 07 Assets/          ← finished reports and documents
├─ 08 Projects/        ← working notes of active projects
├─ 09 MOCs/            ← maps of your themes, and project Doors
├─ Archives/          ← old notes; nothing is ever deleted
├─ Templates/ Excalidraw/
├─ Home.md            ← the front page of your brain
└─ .brain/            ← tools and search index (hidden in Obsidian)
```

### Already have an Obsidian vault?

Point setup at it. It adds the missing sections next to your notes and never moves or deletes what is there.

## Step 5. Verify it worked

Setup checks itself and shows you the result:

```
OK 00 Inbox      OK save-to-obsidian  OK close-session
OK 06 Session Logs OK project-advisor OK brain-health
OK 09 MOCs       OK brain-search   OK CLAUDE.md
OK Archives     OK project-door   0 notes with problems
OK .brain/tools  OK session-checkpoint search finds "Start Here"
```

All OK means your brain is live. If something says MISSING, the brain walks you through the fix before calling setup done. The usual cause is the skills landing in the wrong folder; see Chapter 9.

## What setup created for you

### CLAUDE.md

Your brain's settings: your name, where the vault lives, your language, the rules, and the phrases. The assistant reads it at the start of every conversation.

### CURRENT-CONTEXT.md

A short, living summary of what you are working on right now. Update it about once a week. It is the first note the brain reads.

### Home and Start Here

`Home.md` and `09 MOCs/MOC, Start Here` give the graph a center, so the first notes you save are never alone.

### .brain/

The toolbox: the search index, the note checker, the Door reader, the health check, and `vocabulary.json`, the list of note types.

### Your setup got saved too

The first thing your brain does after setup is write a session log of the setup itself. Its birth certificate is already in `06 Session Logs/`.

## Upgrading from version 1

If you set up your brain with v1 of this kit, you keep everything. Run the install command again (it moves your old skill copies aside), then say:

YOU SAY

**"Upgrade my brain to v2."**

1. It adds the new folders: `References`, `07 Assets`, `08 Projects`, `09 MOCs`, `Archives` and `.brain`.
2. It puts the tools in `.brain/` and builds the first search index.
3. It rewrites `CLAUDE.md` with the v2 template, keeping every line you added.
4. It runs the first health check and shows you the light.

### Do not panic at the first light

An older vault usually starts yellow or red: broken links and notes without the new properties pile up over months. That first number is your baseline, not a grade. The brain compares every month with the one before, and old notes get fixed as you touch them.

## A mental model to keep

YOU

### You talk

In plain language, in your language.

SKILLS

### The skills act

Each one has a job and a phrase that wakes it up.

VAULT

### The vault remembers

Everything lands in a labeled folder, connected to what came before.

### CHAPTER 1 RECAP

- ✓ Ran one install command.
- ✓ Said "Set up my second brain".
- ✓ Answered seven questions.
- ✓ Watched the vault, the toolbox and the settings get built.
- ✓ Saw every check come back OK.

**Stuck?** Chapter 9 has two-line fixes for the usual problems. **Worked?** Next, a tour of your new brain.

## 2 Meet your brain

Your vault is a filing cabinet. Every drawer has a number, a label and a reason.

| Drawer                       | What goes in it                                                                | Example                                             |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>00 Inbox</b>              | Only what does not fit anywhere yet. Empty it now and then                     | A quick thought from your phone                     |
| <b>01 Personal Knowledge</b> | People, places, routines, and lessons learned                                  | "Always confirm the delivery window the day before" |
| <b>02 Strategy</b>           | Vision, goals, your North Star, and the Decision Log                           | "Decision, Raise prices in March"                   |
| <b>03 Ideas &amp; Notes</b>  | Ideas before they are projects; <a href="#">References/</a> for saved articles | "Idea, Monthly newsletter"                          |
| <b>04 Learning</b>           | Books, courses, tech, business                                                 | Notes from a book you finished                      |
| <b>05 AI System</b>          | How your tools and skills fit together; the health history                     | "Brain Health History"                              |
| <b>06 Session Logs</b>       | One record per working session, and project checkpoints                        | "2026-10-02 Session, Garden plan"                   |
| <b>07 Assets</b>             | Finished outputs: reports, dashboards, documents                               | A quote you sent, a yearly summary                  |
| <b>08 Projects</b>           | Working notes of active projects, one folder each                              | "08 Projects/Kitchen Remodel/"                      |
| <b>09 MOCs</b>               | Maps of Content (hubs for a theme) and one Door per project                    | "MOC, Garden" and "Door, Garden"                    |
| <b>Archives</b>              | Old or replaced notes. Nothing is ever deleted; it moves here                  | Last year's plan                                    |

### Rename freely

Skills find drawers by their number, so "01 Personal Knowledge" can become "01 Company Knowledge" and everything keeps working.

### Three words you will see a lot

#### Link

Writing `[[Note Name]]` inside a note connects it to another. Links are the brain's nerves: they are how one idea leads to the next.

#### MOC

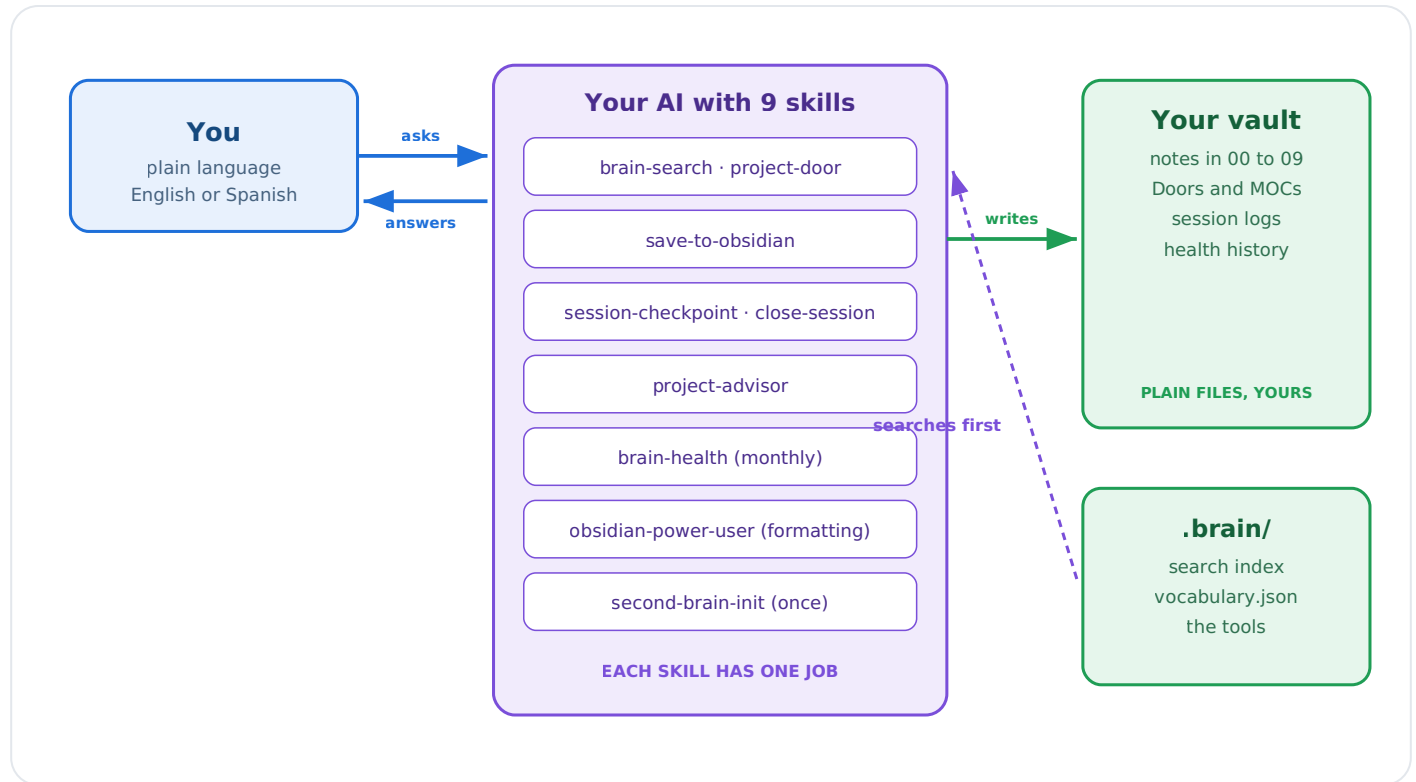
A Map of Content: a note that lists and links everything about one theme. The table of contents of a topic.

#### Door

One note per project that says where it stands today, in one screen. Chapter 5 is all about Doors.

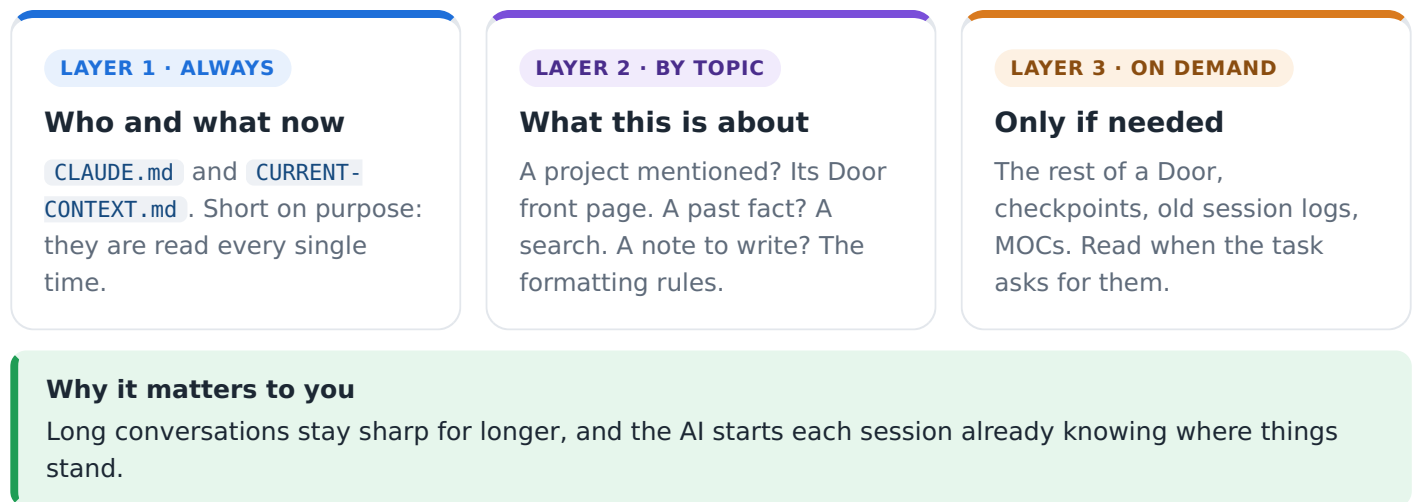
## The whole system on one page

Blue: what you do. Purple: the skills. Green: what lives in your vault. Dashed: reading, not writing.



## How your AI reads the brain: three layers

An AI's memory in one conversation is limited. Loading your whole vault at the start would fill it with history and leave less room for the work. So the brain reads in layers, set up in your [CLAUDE.md](#):



### 3 Saving knowledge

The capture habit. The single most important page in this manual.

Have a normal conversation: plan a project, work through a problem, think out loud. At the end, say:

YOU SAY

**"Save to my brain." · "Guárdalo en mi cerebro."**

The `save-to-obsidian` skill makes two things from the conversation:

#### 1 · KNOWLEDGE

##### Knowledge nuggets

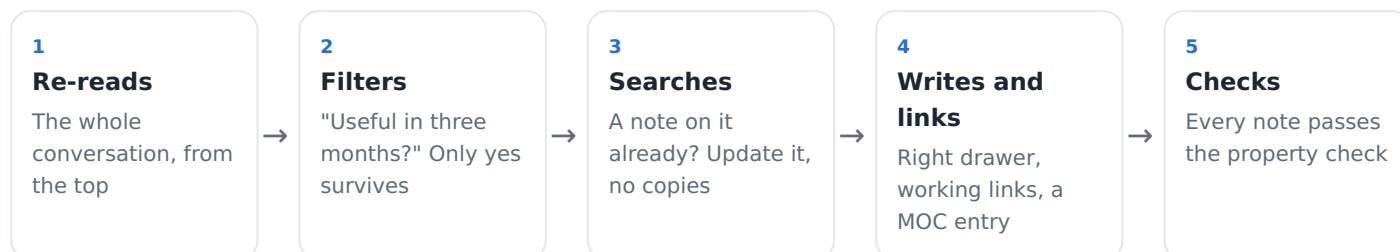
The pieces worth having in three months: a lesson, a decision and its reasons, an idea, something about a person. Each one filed in its drawer and linked to related notes.

#### 2 · RECORD

##### A session log

One record of the whole session in `06 Session Logs/`: what you set out to do, what got done, the decisions, the tools, and what is still open.

### What happens when you say it



### When the brain saves, and when it does not

#### ✓ It saves

- ✓ When you ask, in any words.
- ✓ When it offers once, at the end of a session that produced something real (a decision, a lesson, a new process), and you say yes.

#### ✗ It does not

- ✗ In the middle of a session "just in case".
- ✗ Every time a task finishes.
- ✗ More than one offer per session.

#### Golden rule: save on purpose

A brain full of everything is as useless as an empty one. Saving only what is worth it keeps search sharp and your notes worth reading.

#### Doing the same thing three times?

The brain will offer to turn it into a skill of its own instead of saving it again. Repeated work is a sign of a missing tool.

## The rules that keep every note clean

A vault does not break in one day. It rots slowly: a renamed note leaves dead links, a quick note has no description, a copy is left behind. Version 2 writes every note by these rules so that never starts.

### LINKS

#### Every link works

- ✓ No file names with `# ^ [ ] | :` (Obsidian cannot link them).
- ✓ Before writing `[[A Note]]`, the brain checks that note exists.
- ✓ No "placeholder" links to notes that do not exist yet.
- ✓ Every new note gets at least one link pointing to it, usually from a MOC.

### PROPERTIES

#### Every note has the same header

- ✓ A type, a date and the **real time** from the clock.
- ✓ A one-line description, written for a stranger.
- ✓ Tags in lowercase, and a status (active, done, parked...).
- ✓ A script checks each note before it counts as saved.

This is what that header (Obsidian calls it "properties") looks like:

```
---
title: "Decision, Cedar raised beds"
type: decision
date: 2026-10-02
time: "14:35"
description: "We chose cedar raised beds over in-ground rows; cost and back pain."
tags: [garden, decisions]
status: active
---
```

#### Why so strict?

Search ranks the title and description highest, filters use the type and the date, and the health check trusts the status. When every note has the same header, all of that just works. The list of allowed types lives in `.brain/vocabulary.json`; add your own whenever you need.

## Never delete, never copy

- ✓ **One note per topic.** New knowledge updates the existing note; no "v2" files.
- ✓ **Nothing is deleted.** A note that is no longer true moves to `Archives/` and is marked superseded.
- ✓ **No backup copies inside the vault.** A file like `note.md.bak` confuses search and links; backups go to `Archives/Backups/`.

## Knowledge moves up

A good brain promotes what repeats. A saved article you keep coming back to graduates to a real note. When five notes keep circling the same principle, the brain writes that principle once, as its own note, and links it from a MOC. When a theme grows past about seven notes, it proposes a MOC for it.

## A real save, start to finish

Ana spent forty minutes with her AI planning a vegetable garden: bed material, the watering routine, and a mistake from last year (she planted tomatoes too early and lost them to frost). She said "save to my brain". This is what came back:

Saved to Ana's Brain:

- Decision, Cedar raised beds → 02 Strategy / Decision Log
- Lesson, Plant tomatoes after May 15 → 01 Personal Knowledge / Lessons Learned
- Watering Schedule (updated) → 01 Personal Knowledge / Routines
- Session log → 06 Session Logs

All notes pass the property check. Linked from MOC, Garden.

### What it chose to keep

The decision and its reasons, the frost lesson with the date to remember, and the change to a routine that already had a note (updated, not copied).

### What it left out

The back-and-forth about seed brands that went nowhere. That lives in the session log, in case she ever wants it.

## Where things go

| It is a...                                    | It goes to                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Lesson (went wrong or right, with a takeaway) | 01 .../Lessons Learned                           |
| Decision (a choice and its reasons)           | 02 Strategy/Decision Log                         |
| Idea (to explore later)                       | 03 Ideas & Notes                                 |
| Saved article, quote or clip                  | 03 Ideas & Notes/References                      |
| Book or course takeaway                       | 04 Learning                                      |
| Something about a skill or a tool connection  | 05 AI System (what it is beats what it is about) |
| Finished report or document                   | 07 Assets                                        |

### CHAPTER 3 RECAP

- ✓ End a useful conversation with "save to my brain".
- ✓ You get knowledge notes in the right drawers, plus a session log.
- ✓ Every link works, every note has the same header, nothing is copied or deleted.
- ✓ The brain saves when you ask, or offers once at the end.

## 4 Finding things again

A brain you have to remember to look in is just a folder. This one looks for you.

### Golden rule: search before asking

When the AI needs a fact about your life or work (a decision, a price, a person, how you did something), it searches your notes first. It only asks you when the brain truly has nothing.

### Ask the way you talk

YOU SAY

"What did we decide about the fence?"

YOU SAY

"Have we done something like this before?"

YOU SAY

"¿Qué sé de la familia Ortiz?"

YOU SAY

"Find that article about pricing I saved."

The `brain-search` skill searches, opens the top notes, and answers with what they say, naming each note so you can open it. If two notes disagree, it shows you both, newest first, instead of picking one quietly.

### How it finds things

Setup built a search index of your whole vault inside `.brain/`. Think of it as the index at the back of a book, rebuilt in seconds whenever the brain saves or closes a session.

#### Titles weigh more

A word in the title, the description or the tags counts more than the same word buried in the text. That is why descriptions matter.

#### Accents do not matter

"decision" finds "decisión", and "cafe" finds "café". Search in English or Spanish.

#### All words, then any

It first looks for notes with every word. If none exist, it tries any of them and tells you so.

### Recipes the AI uses for you

| You ask                         | What it does                                                         |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "What did we decide about X?"   | Searches decisions with X in the title, newest first                 |
| "Where did we leave project Y?" | Opens the project's Door first (Chapter 5), then recent session logs |
| "Have we done this before?"     | Searches session logs and lessons for the key words                  |
| "What do I know about Z?"       | Searches people notes first, then everything                         |

## What a good answer looks like

**You:** What did we decide about the fence?

**AI:** Searched the brain for "fence": 3 notes, I read the first two. On September 12 you decided on a cedar fence, 6 feet, along the back line only, because the neighbor is sharing the cost (*[[Decision, Back fence]]*). The quote was \$4,200 (*[[2026-09-12 Session, Fence quotes]]*). One older note from August talked about vinyl; the September decision replaced it.

- ✓ It says where it looked, in one line.
- ✓ It answers from the notes and names each one as a link.
- ✓ It points out the older note that disagrees, instead of hiding it.

## No Python? It still searches

Without Python, the skill falls back to a plain text search of your vault: file names first, then the description lines, then the text. Same rule, same order, just less ranking. Install Python whenever you like; the index is built automatically the next time you save.

## Make your notes easy to find

- **Good titles.** "Decision, Back fence" beats "Thoughts 3".
- **A real description.** One line a stranger would understand. The brain writes it, and it is the line search trusts most.
- **Aliases.** Other names for the same thing ("the Ortiz job", "Ortiz kitchen") go in the aliases property.

### When the brain asks you anyway

It means the search came up empty. Answer, and if the fact will matter again, let it save it. Next time it will not ask.

```
python3 .brain/tools/brain_search.py "fence" --type decision --sort date # what the AI runs, if you are curious
```

## CHAPTER 4 RECAP

- ✓ The AI searches your notes before asking you.
- ✓ Ask in plain words, in English or Spanish.
- ✓ Answers name the notes they come from, and show disagreements.
- ✓ Titles and descriptions are what make notes findable.

## 5 Working on projects

How a project picks up exactly where it left off, even after weeks away.

Without help, resuming a project means digging through old conversations and guessing which one is current. Version 2 gives every project three tools: a **Door** to open it, **checkpoints** while you work, and a **close** when you stop.

### The Door: one page per project

A Door is a note in `09 MOCs/` called `Door, <Project>`. It says where the project stands today, in one screen, and it is the first thing the brain reads when you start working on that project.

| # | Section                    | What it holds                                           |
|---|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Current state</b>       | 3 to 6 lines of what is true today                      |
| 2 | <b>Numbers that matter</b> | The few figures that drive decisions, with their source |
| 3 | <b>Next steps</b>          | Checkboxes, and who owns each                           |
| 4 | How it runs                | How to operate it. Read only when needed                |
| 5 | Where everything lives     | Links to the MOC, decisions, files                      |
| 6 | History                    | One line per change, newest first                       |

Sections 1 to 3 are the **front page**: that is all the brain reads to start. The rest waits until it is needed.

```
type: door · project: garden
verified: 2026-10-02
```

#### Door, Garden

##### 1. Current state

Three cedar beds built. Soil delivered. Planting starts after May 15 (frost lesson).

##### 2. Numbers that matter

Spent \$640 of \$900 budget (receipts note, Oct 1).  
Beds: 3 of 4.

##### 3. Next steps

- ☐ Build bed 4 (Ana)
- ☐ Order drip kit (Luis)
- ☒ Fill beds with soil

##### 4 to 6

How it runs · Where things live · History

#### YOU SAY

"Let's work on the garden." · "¿En qué quedamos con el huerto?"

The brain opens the Door, tells you in one line where things stand and what is next, and gets to work. If the Door was last checked more than a week ago, it says so and checks the numbers before deciding anything.

#### Starting something new?

Say "new project: kitchen remodel". The brain creates its Door, adds the project to your list, and links it from a MOC so it is never an orphan.

## Checkpoints: a save point while you work

In a long conversation, the AI eventually compresses the beginning to make room, a bit like keeping only the summary of the first chapters of a book. Details blur. A **checkpoint** is a save point, like in a video game: every 15 to 20 exchanges, at each milestone, and before any heavy step, the brain writes where the work stands to `06 Session Logs/Active Session State, <Project>`.

### One file per project

Each project has its own checkpoint, overwritten each time. Two projects in one day never erase each other.

### After a compression

The brain re-reads the checkpoint and tells you: "the conversation was compressed; we are at...". Then it carries on. You do nothing.

## Closing a session

When you are done for the day, say:

YOU SAY

**"Close the session." · "Continuamos mañana." · "Blindemos."**

1

### Checkpoint

The working state, current

→

2

### Door

Sections 1 to 3 rewritten, verified today

→

3

### Save

Knowledge and the session log

→

4

### Index

Search rebuilt with today's notes

→

5

### Git

Optional: a safe commit of the vault

### Golden rule: freeze, then write

All five steps describe the same moment. The brain decides what is true now, then writes it everywhere, so the checkpoint, the Door and the log never tell three different stories.

You get a five-line summary:

Session closed:

- Checkpoint: Active Session State, Garden (updated)
- Door: Door, Garden (verified today; next step: build bed 4)
- Brain: 2 notes + session log, all pass the property check
- Index: rebuilt, 412 notes
- Git: not a repo (skipped)

### About the git step

Only if your vault is a git repository (a technical way to keep versions). It pulls changes from your other computer only when they line up cleanly; if they do not, it stops and tells you instead of mixing them. It is the only thing that commits the vault, so turn off any plugin that commits on its own.

## A project day, start to finish

| When            | You                                  | The brain                                                                                    |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 8:00            | "Let's work on the kitchen remodel." | Reads the Door's front page: cabinets ordered, waiting on the plumber's quote, budget at 62% |
| 8:05            | "Did we ever pick a sink?"           | Searches: a decision from September, undermount steel sink, with the model number            |
| 9:30            | (long planning session)              | Writes a checkpoint after the layout milestone                                               |
| 11:00           | (the conversation gets long)         | Notices the compression, re-reads the checkpoint, carries on                                 |
| 12:00           | "Close the session."                 | Checkpoint, Door rewritten, new decision saved, index rebuilt. Five-line summary             |
| Two weeks later | "Where are we with the kitchen?"     | One line from the Door: what is done, what is next, and that the numbers are 14 days old     |

## Which note answers which question

| Note               | Answers                               | Changes                  |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Door</b>        | Where does the project stand today?   | Rewritten at every close |
| <b>Checkpoint</b>  | What were we doing an hour ago?       | During a long session    |
| <b>Session log</b> | What happened in that session?        | Never, once written      |
| <b>MOC</b>         | Where is everything about this theme? | When notes are added     |

### CHAPTER 5 RECAP

- ✓ Every project has a Door: one screen, read first.
- ✓ Long sessions get checkpoints, and recover by themselves.
- ✓ "Close the session" updates everything at once, describing the same moment.
- ✓ Numbers in a Door are only updated when they were checked.

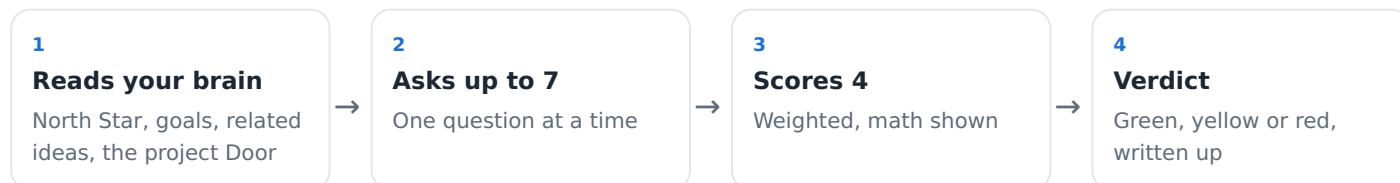
## 6 Deciding what to build

The idea filter. Before you build anything, run it through this.

Every "yes" to a new project is a silent "no" to something else. Ideas feel exciting in the moment, and excitement is a terrible judge of what is worth building now. The `project-advisor` skill is a quick, honest filter that catches every idea before it eats your week.

### YOU SAY

"Should I do this?" · "¿Vale la pena este proyecto?"



### The seven questions

| # | The question                                        | What it is really asking                                 |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | In one sentence, what is this?                      | Can you say it clearly? Fuzzy ideas are not ready        |
| 2 | What problem does it solve, and whose?              | A real problem, or just novelty?                         |
| 3 | How is it handled today?                            | Does it replace painful manual work, or invent new work? |
| 4 | What does success look like in 90 days?             | If you cannot name a number, it is not ready             |
| 5 | What will it cost to build?                         | Time, money, tools. A rough guess is fine                |
| 6 | If you build this, what does not get built?         | The most important one. Every yes is a no                |
| 7 | Which part of your life or work does it strengthen? | Only asked if still unclear                              |

### The scorecard

| Dimension                                         | Weight | Score      | Verdict                        |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------|------------|--------------------------------|
| Systemization: turns repeated work into a system? | 25%    | 7.5 to 10  | ● <b>GREEN:</b> build it       |
| North Star: moves you toward your vision?         | 30%    | 5.0 to 7.4 | ● <b>YELLOW:</b> refine first  |
| Revenue or cost: makes or saves money?            | 25%    | 0 to 4.9   | ● <b>RED:</b> shelve it, saved |
| Timing: is now the right moment?                  | 20%    |            |                                |

### Two honesty rules

**Override:** North Star 9 or 10 and a total of at least 5.0 bumps it to green. **Veto:** Timing 1 or 2 caps it at yellow, however high the rest is.

## A worked example

**You:** Should I do this? A weekly email that summarizes everything new in my industry.

**Advisor:** (searches the brain: your North Star says "stay current without doom-scrolling"; your Door for the spring launch shows you are mid-launch this week.)

| Dimension       | Score | Weight | Weighted    |
|-----------------|-------|--------|-------------|
| Systemization   | 8     | 25%    | 2.00        |
| North Star      | 9     | 30%    | 2.70        |
| Revenue or cost | 4     | 25%    | 1.00        |
| Timing          | 3     | 20%    | 0.60        |
| <b>Total</b>    |       |        | <b>6.30</b> |

Raw verdict yellow (6.3). The override applies (North Star 9, total over 5.0), so it is **green**, and the write-up is honest that timing is weak: start after this week's launch ships.

Every run writes an idea note in [03 Ideas & Notes](#), a Decision Log entry for green or red, a printable brief, and (if you turned it on) a Notion entry. Red ideas are parked with what would bring them back, never thrown away.

### CHAPTER 6 RECAP

- ✓ "Should I do this?", up to seven questions, four scores, one verdict with the math shown.
- ✓ It reads your brain first, so the advice fits your priorities.

## 7 Power moves

The skill you use the most and think about the least.

Whenever another skill writes to your vault, it first loads `obsidian-power-user`. That is why your notes come out with proper headers, working links and tidy callout boxes without you asking. Like a spell-checker, it runs in the background. When you call it on purpose, it is a full Obsidian expert:

### A template

"Make me a weekly review template." A reusable note shape you fill in every week.

### A canvas

"Make a canvas to plan the move." A visual board of cards you arrange and connect.

### A map or dashboard

"Make a MOC of everything about pricing." Or a base: a table view of notes filtered by type or date.

### A clean note from a mess

Paste rough notes and say "turn this into a proper note". Header, links and all.

### An import

"Help me bring my notes from Apple Notes." It knows the importers for Notion, Evernote, Apple Notes, Roam and more, and what survives the trip.

### A query

"Show me every decision from this year in one list." A Dataview query or a base that updates itself.

### You do not need the jargon

Describe what you want in plain words. It knows which Obsidian feature fits, and it follows the same link and header rules as every other skill.

### CHAPTER 7 RECAP

- ✓ It runs behind every other skill, so notes come out clean.
- ✓ Ask it directly for templates, canvases, maps, imports and queries, in plain words.

## 8 Keeping it healthy

A brain rots quietly. Measured once a month with the same rules, it is caught while it is small.

None of the problems below hurts on the day it happens: a renamed note leaves a dead link, a quick save leaves an orphan, a copy is left behind. Together, over months, they turn a brain into a junk drawer. The `brain-health` skill measures nine things, the same way every month, and keeps the history.

| Measure             | What it means                                      | Healthy                |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>Notes</b>        | How many, and per drawer                           | Growing where you work |
| <b>Broken links</b> | Links that point to a note that does not exist     | Going down             |
| <b>Orphans</b>      | Notes nothing links to, so you never run into them | Few, shrinking         |
| <b>No header</b>    | Notes without the properties block                 | 0 for new notes        |
| <b>Contract</b>     | % of notes that pass the property check            | Going up               |
| <b>.bak files</b>   | Backup copies sitting inside the vault             | Always 0               |
| <b>Duplicates</b>   | Notes that are exact copies of another             | 0                      |
| <b>Bad names</b>    | File names Obsidian cannot link                    | 0                      |
| <b>Stale Doors</b>  | Project Doors not checked in 30 days               | 0                      |

### The traffic light

RED

#### Fix this month

Backup files inside the vault, or broken links grew more than 10% since last month.

YELLOW

#### Keep an eye

Broken links grew a little, the contract % dropped, or there are bad names or stale Doors.

GREEN

#### Healthy

None of the above. Keep doing what you are doing.

#### Golden rule: compare with last month, not with perfection

An old vault can start with hundreds of broken links. That is fine as long as the number goes down. The light looks at the direction, not the size.

## It runs by itself, once a month

If you said yes to question 7 at setup, the check runs on the **1st of every month at 07:00**, rebuilds the search index, and adds one row to `05 AI System/Brain Health History`. Nothing else is touched. To see it or change it:

### YOU SAY

**"How is my brain doing?" · "Salud del cerebro."**

### YOU SAY

**"Turn off the monthly check." · "Apaga la revisión mensual."**

Behind the scenes: macOS uses `launchd`, Linux uses `cron`, and on Windows the brain gives you one line to paste. On a Mac with the vault in iCloud, the first run may ask for Full Disk Access for Python (System Settings, Privacy and Security); the brain tells you if so.

## How the answer looks

**AI:** Brain health, October 1: **YELLOW**. Broken links went from 41 to 47, mostly one note: six notes link to "Supplier List", which was renamed. Orphans 12 (was 15, good). Contract 88% (was 85%).

Three fixes, most useful first: 1) point the six links to "Suppliers"; 2) link the 3 newest orphans from their MOC; 3) verify the Door for the garden (32 days old). Want me to do them?

## How the fixes work

- ✓ **Backup files:** moved to `Archives/Backups/`. Never deleted.
- ✓ **Broken links:** the missing note is created as a short stub, or the link is pointed at the right name. One fix often repairs many links.
- ✓ **Orphans:** linked from their MOC or a related note, or archived if truly dead.
- ✓ **Property check:** the brain lists each note and what is missing, newest notes first.
- ✓ **Stale Doors:** verified with you, or the project is marked parked.

### Two months in a row not green?

The numbers cannot see everything. The brain will offer a deeper review: notes that contradict each other, plans that are no longer true, MOCs that no longer match the vault.

## Your five-minute weekly habit

Once a week, refresh `CURRENT-CONTEXT.md`: active projects (each linking its Door), this week's focus, open questions, recent decisions. It is the first note your brain reads, so keeping it current is the highest-value habit after saving. Ask: *"Help me update my current context for this week."*

### CHAPTER 8 RECAP

- ✓ Monthly: the checkup runs itself and writes one history row.
- ✓ Weekly: five minutes on `CURRENT-CONTEXT.md`.
- ✓ Fix at most three things at a time, most repeated first.

## 9 Troubleshooting and FAQ

There is little to break. Here is what people occasionally hit, with the fix.

### "The brain cannot find my vault."

The vault folder is not connected to your assistant in this session. In Cowork, grant access to the folder; elsewhere, open the assistant in or near the vault. The brain never writes notes somewhere random as a workaround; it stops and asks.

### "It did not trigger when I said the phrase."

Say it more directly: "Save this to my brain." Still nothing? The skills may be in the wrong folder (Chapter 1, Step 1). Run the install command again and start a fresh conversation.

### "Search says there is no index."

Ask: "rebuild the search index." It takes seconds. If it says Python or FTS5 is missing, install Python from python.org; until then search uses plain text.

### "The property check fails on my notes."

Normal for notes written by hand or before v2. Ask "fix the properties of this note". If a type or project is new, add it to `.brain/vocabulary.json` (the brain can do it).

### "The monthly check never ran."

Ask "is the monthly check on?" The brain shows the status and the last log lines. On a Mac with iCloud, give Python Full Disk Access. If the computer was off on the 1st, macOS runs it when it wakes.

### "The close stopped at the git step."

Your vault changed on two computers and the changes do not line up. The brain stopped on purpose so nothing gets mixed up. Ask it to show you the difference and decide together.

### "It answered in the wrong language."

Tell it: "answer in English" or "responde en español". For good, change the language line in `CLAUDE.md`.

### "I ran setup twice."

No harm. Setup sees your brain exists and asks: keep it, change some answers, or start over. Choose keep.

### "I do not have Obsidian."

Your brain still works: notes are plain text files. Install Obsidian (free) whenever you want the graph and clickable links.

### "Do I have to use Notion?"

No. It only touches the idea filter, and only if you turned it on.

### When in doubt, ask the brain

"Why did my save not work?" or "Is my vault connected?" usually gets a straight answer and a fix faster than this page.

## Quick FAQ

|                                             |                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Will it work on my phone?</b>            | Your notes sync if the vault is in iCloud, OneDrive or Dropbox. The skills run wherever you use your assistant. |
| <b>Can I rename the folders?</b>            | Yes. Keep the number in front (01, 02...) and everything keeps working.                                         |
| <b>Is my data private?</b>                  | Yes. Everything stays in your vault, on your computer or your cloud drive, in plain files.                      |
| <b>Does anything run in the background?</b> | Only the monthly health check, and only if you said yes.                                                        |
| <b>What if I stop using the kit?</b>        | You keep every note, forever.                                                                                   |
| <b>Can I share the kit?</b>                 | Yes, that is the point. It is free under the MIT license.                                                       |

## CHAPTER 10

### 10 Growing your brain

You started with scattered knowledge. You end with a system that remembers, finds, and looks after itself.

#### Name your North Star

After a few weeks, write in `CLAUDE.md` the one outcome you are building toward. It sharpens the idea filter more than anything else.

#### Teach it your world

Add the people who matter, your vocabulary and nicknames to `CLAUDE.md`. Keep it short; move detail into notes and link them.

#### Add your own types

Track recipes, clients, properties? Add a type to `.brain/vocabulary.json` and every tool follows.

#### Build a pack for your trade

The same base can learn a trade: painters, real estate, consulting, restaurants. Use it a few weeks first; you will see what your trade needs.

#### The best way to learn it is to teach it

Walk a friend through setup. It takes ten minutes, and now there are two of you with a second brain.

## A final word

You do not have to be technical to think clearly, decide well and remember what matters. The hard part was having a place for it all. Now you do. Start small: save one conversation today, open one project through its Door, and let the brain take care of the rest.

# Glossary

The words in this manual, in plain language.

## Vault

The folder that holds your brain. Obsidian calls it a vault.

## Skill

A folder of instructions that teaches your AI one job.

## Link

`[[Note Name]]` inside a note: a doorway to another note.

## Broken link

A doorway to a room that does not exist.

## Orphan

A note nothing links to. You will never stumble on it again.

## Properties

The header at the top of a note: type, date, time, description, tags, status.

## MOC

Map of Content: the table of contents of one theme.

## Door

One note per project: where it stands today, in one screen.

## Front page

Sections 1 to 3 of a Door, the only part read to start.

## Checkpoint

A save point of a long session, one per project.

## Compression

When a long conversation gets summarized to make room.

## Search index

Like the index at the back of a book, for your whole vault.

## Session log

The record of one working session.

## North Star

The one long-term outcome you are building toward.

## The reference card

| Say this                                | And this happens                                   |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| "Save to my brain" · "Guárdalo"         | Knowledge filed, session logged, links checked     |
| "What did we decide about X?"           | The brain searches before answering                |
| "Let's work on X" · "¿En qué quedamos?" | The project Door opens: state, numbers, next steps |
| "New project: X"                        | A Door is created and linked                       |
| "Close the session" · "Blindemos"       | Checkpoint, Door, save, index, in one go           |
| "Should I do this?"                     | Seven questions, four scores, one verdict          |
| "How is my brain doing?"                | The traffic light and the top three fixes          |